city's favelas, led to the notion that 'the favela has won!' in the late 1990s (Zaluar and Alvito 1998). One of their arguments was that favelas were no longer at risk of removal and most people defended their urbanisation instead. Was Rio de Janeiro about to become an 'exception from the exception' – a city for the dispossessed masses?

With the supposedly pro-poor policies of the governments after 2003, when Inácio Lula da Silva from the Workers Party (PT) became president, one may presume that the old divides between the 'favela' and the 'asphalt' are being erased. The federal government is investing unprecedented amounts on large-scale programmes for slum upgrading, social housing and improved infrastructures. The main references are the federal Programme for Accelerated Growth (PAC) and My House My Life (MCMV). In Rio de Janeiro, these programmes are tightly connected with the mega-events.

There are ample opportunities for host cities to use mega-sports events like the World Cup and the Olympics, and the capital and investments coming with them, as a concrete tool for social change. The massive public spending required to be able to pull off such events often faces local opposition. Leaving a positive legacy is therefore one of the recent concerns of the 'Olympic system' as a way of legitimising itself (Horne and Whannel 2012). Cities in the bidding process present a legacy plan on how they will use the event to address the city's social, economic, infrastructural and planning challenges as a central aspect of their candidacy, often going beyond what is strictly necessary in order to stage the Games. The last Olympic Games to be hosted, the 2012 London Games, were applauded for a legacy plan that emphasised the urban regeneration of selected underprivileged neighbourhoods. Rio de Janeiro also has an ambitious plan to use the Olympics for citywide transformation. Legacy plans range from housing improvements to crime reduction, social inclusion, regeneration, and communications infrastructure combined with an attempt to revive the city's national and international image (Girginov 2013:301). The Morar Carioca Programme pledged a social legacy from the Olympic Games in terms of comprehensive upgrading of all the favelas in Rio de Janeiro by 2020 (Prefeitura do Rio de Janeiro 2010; Bittar 2011). In the Sustainability Management Plan of the Olympics (SMP), developed by the municipality of Rio de Janeiro, the city government states that one of the strategic objectives of the municipal planning department is to 'organise an all-inclusive Games, leaving the city's population with a positive social balance'. No wonder that in a soccer-crazy country such as Brazil, the prospect of hosting the FIFA World Cup initially had wide support.

Sport, once viewed as a form of entertainment, has now emerged as an